SIX - TRADITIONS

A. vigilance / atmosphere of recovery

B. freedom for the individual

C. freedom for the group

D. traditions

SEVEN - RECOVERY AND RELAPSE

A. recovery concept

1. define

2. quality

3. quantity

4. relapse and return

B. stumbling blocks and how we react to them

EIGHT - WE DO RECOVER

A. identification - similarities and differences

B. dilema - obsession / compulsion

1 deciding to live

2 on-going recovery

3 physical

4 mental

5 spiritual

6 living by example

7 powerlessness

8 gratitude

9 creative freedom

10 promises - the lie is dead

#8 We do recover

A. I learned what true friendship and usefulness was. I found I could be honest and didn't have to hide the s of me I didn't like

When it hurt I drank when I could have grown I used chemicals. When you dont understand its a gift from God

What we have in common, what we have all felt, is the aloneness, seperateness, misery and dispair; the pain inside us, in the empty numbness that set us apart from our fellows. The one thing we all share, the uniting factor, is that we all felt that we were unique, different, better than or worse than, but always seperate. We had a very empty place inside us. We felt we were alone. Our pain surrounded us, but didn't fill the empty place inside us.

Unfortunatly many of the mental and physical states resulting from this kind of addiction make it more likely that the person will consider themselves victims of diseases which have no recoveryp program available but only vague forms of treatment that can go on indefinitely unless the real nature of their illness is discovered. The best rule we've found is that if you think you might have a problem with drugs you probably do.

0059 8-A

In comparing parts of our past with others it would seem that we all reach a point, soon or late, when we say to ourselves or others "I just don't have a way to go, if I only knew what to do."

#8 Hope

8-A We do have a common bond of chemical addiction, of mysteriously twisted personalities. We both have experienced that terrifyingly overwhelming urge, that need for something outside of oneself. I know the feelings all too well. We share a bond of fear, of anxiety, of anger that we are unable to control.

Drug addicts could not reform. Before the start of N.A. in 1953 addicts did not but in rare instances re cover. Powerless to reform, tormented by disease many of us died. many in our sister program Alcoholics Anonomous wished for an amswer. A life line and program of living without the use of drugs for the suffering drug addict to whom suicide seemed to be the inevitable answer either very very slow or

loneliness and the old ways of addiction thinking pushed me back into that first pill, fix, drink, toke etc

8 WE DO RECOVER

A IDENTIFICATION

Although I had used, misused and abused medications for half of my life, I never considered that I might be an addict. For me, the term "drug addiction" conjured up visions of street crime, fear of the law, and needles. As far as I chose to believe, the drug addict lived in a skid row environment; and because I did not fit the picture I had imagined,,I could not be a "drug addict". I had never been arrested, I had no fear of the law, and I was afreid of the needle.

Although I drank heavily and experimented with drugs in high school, I never really used drugs seriously until I was twenty. I had a unhappy marriage, and I had the usual woes of a young mother. At the insistance of my husband, I sought psychiatric help for my "nerves". I sought help in this manner until I finally came into NA.

> [illegible] proud they were [illegible]. I knew I had an alchol problem and knew sooner or later I would start drinking alcholically, little didI know, I already was. I felt as though I would be able to drink about fifteen years before I would be in any trouble. I didn't know that I had a disease or know about the progression of the disease. So, within a five year span there was no wife, no kids, no home, no business, no car, no money and no hope.

When I got to Alcoholics Anonymous in 1974 I knew instinctively that staying sober meant staying off all mood changing drugs as well. As A.A. was for booze I didn't talk about my drug taking very much. I only occasionally mentioned my midnight drives to the paddy fields outside Saigon when I was stoned or drunk, and the paranoia I felt the last time I smoked hashish in Algeciras, Spain. My taking of Stelazine, a major tranquiliser, I put out of my mind altogether.

> Any drug addict clean and sober without a compulsion to use is a miracle. To keep the miracle alive in ongoing recovery involves personal growth in attitudes and awareness.It is important to remember that recovery is an abnormal state for us addicts. We learn to live clean and sober. If we find ourselves in trouble with our recovery after some time clean and sober, we have usually stopped doing one or more of the things that helped us in the earlier stages of our recovery. This can show up as an unexplanable depression or disorientation but is really related to a poor spiritual condition.

8 WE Do RECOVER (3)

A IDENTIFICATION

If you are in the program and find yourself cultivating feelings of isolation and dispair don't feel alone. Many of us have had similiar difficulties at different stages in our recoveries. Usually they come at a time of great potential growth. In other words self destructiveness will make us want to go out and use again instead of recovering. We can overcome this if we make a special effort to share our feelings at a meeting, in fellowship or with a friend or sponsor. By doing this we are moving out of ourselves rather than inwardly. We don't want to protect, hide or cherish negativity. By getting it out we run a better chance of encountering someone who may be able to help us. Many of us find our own answers dawning on us while we are trying to explain the problem to some one else.

H 0183

Note is daily log
Jolene Ryan

Note: This entry was made three months before NA become known to author.

#8 For some life is the living the here and the now. There is bitter and there is sweet; yet all remains ephemeral. For others, life is in the future. Carefully considered sucesses are not always achieved; and there is disappointment - then regret. And for a few, life is in the past, the memories. They are blind to the future and unaware of the present. They see the future as an extention of the past; so their lives are of self-fufilling prophecy. These are the szddest of all; and I am one.

Note; This entry was made four months before author came into NA.

#5 By aaressing the minutes, I am able to endure the endless hours. There is comfort in my carefully measured footsteps ad they divide the day. Each step, each moment, puts me closer to my goal, or my death. Each promises peace. But for now, there is only the moment and I endure.

and sharing your experience of the disease concept with your new people, youcan give them knowledge that may save their lives. Most people just don't know about the progressive and incurable aspects of our disease until they come to the program and sit through a few meetings. Until they have their own understanding of the disease and how it has affected their lives they have little hope of ongoing recovery. By keeping it simple

& WE DO RECOVER
A TESTIFICATION

During the years of my using, I spent a great daal of time in one of my many doctors offices. I got scripts for every imaginable conditon, from depression, to mania, to physical complaints. I knew that the drugs felt good, but I believed that I was treating my conditions rather than feeding an all-cOnsuming disease. I began developing symptoms that, although they were real enough at the time, served me well when I sought a particular drug. I learned quickly how to get any particular medication.

Over the years I endured many surgeries, that I believ now were actively sough by me to obtain drugs. I became a sick individual. I spent a good many months, over a span fo ten or more years, in mental institutions, being treated with the drugs that I was becoming a slave to. My days were spent in obtaining drugs and using them. I felt that I was free, but I was a slave to myself and my drugs of choice.

After I admitted and accepted that I was, indeed, a drug addict, I became painfully aware that there were few women my age in treatment or in Na. Where were these women that I knew still suffered. Most of them were and are in sheltered situations, living with a husband, parents, of boyfriend. A great deal of them still live under the assumption that they are sick or crazy, when they are in the legions of drug addicts. They spend years in and out of hospitals and doctors offices, cashing scripts and dying.

No one can even guess how many women, house wives and mothers, die as a direct result of drug abuse and addiction. How many accidents occur while the victim is under the influence? Because of my experience with drugs and illness, I belive that a great many deaths of women are caused by drugs and attributed to other causes, such as heart attack, "natural" causes, and accident. Women are dying everyday, overdoseng on housewife's little helpers. Until we recognize just who is an addict and how we can help him, many will die needlessly..I will do all I can help in this work. I am gratefrl to my God and to the NA for being there when I sought help.

Jolene Myers
9-10-90

Their

exists no model of the recovered addict. When the drugs go and the addicts works the program, strange and wonderful things happen. New possibilities spring up like flowers in the desert. Lost dreams awaken. The juices of life begin to flow.

& WE DO RECOVER

A IDENTIFICATION

(3)

This women seem to radiate a feeling of love & joy that I had never felt ffb anyone befor, upon meeting her I felt like than I had known her forever, something in me was drawn to her, little did I know that this women would become my sponsor and play such a big part in my life for the next 10 years, ~~this was to be~~. This was the beginning of a journey that even today never ceased to amaze me, a way of life of learning complete trust in a higher power and to learn a love that has no precetag, a way of life where the constant thought of others must become automatic.

0030

caring. At first we can do little more than attend meetings and that is plenty.! Probably we can't remember even a single name or word or thought from our first meeting. What we do remember is the feelingwe get and every human being craves, the feeling that we belong someplace.

0059

Staying clean and sober is the main purpose of the program of N.A. Gaining strength and guidance leads us into a new life that is beyond the imagination of the operating addict or the newcomer. Nothing is forever and whereever we find ourselves coming in rest assured that we are going to experience many miracles as we progress step by step. The original desire to be clean is the fla me that we should feed. It will burn away all the old ideas that hold us back and make us ready to begin our new lives.

8 WE DO RECOVER
A IDENTIFICATION

I FINNALLY ACCEPTED MY DISEASE THEN I COULD DO SOMETHING ABOUT MY ADDICTION.FEELING GOOD ABOUT MYSEFL AND CARING FOR OTHER PEOPLE GOSE HAND AND HAND WITH RECOVERY. POSITIVE EMOTIONS START LEARNING TO DEAL ANDHLIVE WITH THE NEGATIVE EMOTIONS. HOW CAN I OVERCOME MY ADDICTIONS THE ANWSERRIS. I WILLNNEVER OVERCOME MY ADDICTION. I CAN DEAL WITH A GROW POSITIVE THOUGH MEETINGIN N.A. , TALKING SHARING WITH PEOPLE AND AND BEST OF ALL WORKING THE STEPS. I POWERLESS OVER DRUG'S AND TO USE WOULD ONLY DAMEAGE WHAT POSITIVE EMOTIONS I STILL HAVE YOU CAN R RECOVER AND LIVE DRUG FREE FEELING GOOD AND BRING GREATFUL THAT YOU YDON'T YOU HAVE TO DIE IN THE GUTTER USING. WE DO GET BETTER IF YOU W WANT TO GET BETTER. #0146 8-A

3) It's the beautiful simplicity of this idea that makes it hard to accept — it answers any question we could possibly use as an "excuse" to use drugs — we start getting answers and find them much more "stable" than our excuses — the truth and simplicity of it scares the shit out of us — I love it!

8-0105

The fellowship of AA took me in and threw their protective arms around me. Because I had become hostile, suspicious, and rebellious, I wasn't able to accept my family's love, and the older AA members became substitute parents for me. At the time, the only young people in our local groups were still a lot older than I was, or had been through totally different past histories, which I had trouble identifying with. I was eager for the love that was offered by the older people, even though I was often in the role of a protected child. Maybe I needed that.

Slowly but surely, some younger, hipper, more drug-oriented kids started to trickle in. Meanwhile, I was watching some of the people I had gotten off with fall on their faces again and again, going from one drug program to another, from one hospital to another. I felt lucky to be clean myself, but I felt more and more isolated, more and more different, as time wore on. It was weird watching the progression. First, they would get clean, then they would go out and try it again, then they would get clean again, and this time they were just going to drink. Fortunately, that drew a couple of the few that lived through it to AA.

After watching all that for about four years, I decided that the whole thing was ridiculous, and I am not the only person that thought that way. Last winter, a song-writer blew into town from Florida, with the intention of staying here for a while. He was an AA member, but he said he got into AA through the back door. The back door was Narcotics Anonymous. In West Palm Beach, where Steve had been living, Narcotics Anonymous was active, thriving, and attractive, and he though it was about time we had it here.

1. **It Was Me** 0105

It wasn't the fault of the booze or the drugs. I knew it was me. I was just too screwed-up to be alive and content in the world, as it was set-up. I had two illegitimate pregnancies in two years, that my parents had to pick up the damages on. I was always coming down with a new social disease, and there was no mistaking where I was contracting them. The people I attracted, and the ones that I was drawn to, were the misfits, the unclean, the Bohemian. Yes, I still like people that are different, people that think for themselves. But, in those days, I had an absolute contempt for people that lived the "straight life." When it was legal for me to get away from my family, I did so. I traveled a lot, mostly hitchhiking. It was a lot more dangerous than I had imagined, and the only thing nobody ever did to me was kill me, but I'm lucky to have escaped with my life. I fell in love over and over again, and put myself through many sick, blood-sucking sexual relationships. Some of the people I loved even met their deaths through drugs and addiction, but I used them as further excuses to destroy myself. I had been an intelligent kid in school, but my mind became too muddled to read anything more complex than a comic book for a long time. As for my personality, I had really thought of myself as an outgoing, happy-go-lucky girl, but I was wrong, and after years of depending on drugs and other people to make my decisions, I lost almost all ability to socialize.

& WE Do RECOVER
A Identification

NA NEWSLETTER

THE VOICE OF N.A. Vol. I Feb.'68

It has taken us a long time to start this paper but if we bring to mind the saying"All past is Prologue" we can realize how well it applies to us. Increased hope for more and better recoveries comes from a better understanding of our disorder plus the experience of addicts who have long term recovery.

In the past about all that was really known about the addict encompassed only a small segment of addiction. Since there were few if any real recoveries how could anything else be known, except our behavior while using, during withdrawal and thru' some short periods of abstinence. Even when long periods of abstinence had been imposed upon us nothing really changed to bring about real freedom from drugs.

There were times in our drug using careers when we were convinced that all we had to do to control our using was to quit after the second, or the fifth or the tenth or the twentieth time that got us "loaded"; it was the first! The first time was the one that did the damage. The first time was the one that started us on our merry-go-rounds. The first time was the one that set up a chain reaction of addictive thinking that led to our uncontrolled using.

Another thing that many of us learned during our using days was that enforced "being clean" was generally not a very pleasant ewperience. Some of us were able to stay clean, occasionally, for periods of days, weeks andeven years. But we did not enjoy our being clean. We felt like martyrs. We became irritable, difficult to live and work with. We persisted in looking forward to the time when we might be able to use drugs again.

Now that we are in N.A., we have a new outlook on being clean. We enjoy a sense of release, a feeling of freedom from even the desire to use

8 WE DO RECOVER ⑧
A IDENTIFICATION

0012

Danelle S.
12005 A ~~Van~~ Vanowen
No. Hollywood, CA 91605

8/10

When I got to this program I knew I was dying - mentally, spiritually and physically. I had been using drugs and alcohol for the past 12-13 years with brief periods of what I thought were control and never a thought of complete abstinence. Since being clean and sober, I've been able to look back at my addictive behavior and realized that my ability to cope has never been up to par. I remember, even at the age of 9, the need to avoid pain; taking 15 & 20 aspirin a day because that's what I knew made me feel better if anything hurt. What I didn't know at that time and didn't learn until coming to N.A. was that my pain was not physical but emotional and eventually spritual. Anyways, for the next 13 yrs. I attempted to fill that hole in my gut with anything I could, starting with L.S.D. in the mid-hippie days to find a higher power I could control, eventually getting involved in witchcraft and black magic. There is a long period of confusion after that- my memory of dates and sequence of events is poor. I was taking a lot of downers, uppers, weed, alcohol and drugstore dope. I was arrested once, spent a short period in juvenile hall and saw a probation officer three times afterwards. There were many times later in my drug career, I thought of looking that P.O. up and asking her "Didn't you know, couldn't you see- Why didn't you lock me away then?" But that ability to put up a good front, along with many other things, is what drove me to the gates of insanity and I know today there was no one person, place or thing responsible for my actions.

#1

It was never again necessary for me to come into contact with the law but I can tell you every feeling of every person who has ever done time because I was locked down in a prison of my own making. I continued to take chemicals of all sort, eventually shooting heroin with the rest of the gang. I believe that part of my early using was due to my need to be accepted but as it progressed I became more and more self-centered and by the time I got my first fix I know I was doing it because I had to - for me - to be able to survive in this lonely, frightening world. For the next 7 yrs. my life was a series of runs and clean-ups. I think one of the reasons I stayed out there as long as I did was because I believed I had a certain amount of control. Somehow I held jobs most of the time, I got married (to another hype) and had a son. Of course, I didn't take into consideration the fact that I had to quit jobs before they fired me for stealing their money or the fact that I got married kicking a habit and also stayed strung out during my pregnancy and left the hospital with my son 15 hrs. after delivery because I was sick and had to fix.

8A

I kept trying to prove to myself that it wasn't as bad as it seemed, that I could get it together one way or another. I moved to different towns, got different jobs, saw psychiatrist and doctors, read self-help/awareness books, switched from drug to drug, tried methadone on and off the streets but the obsessive, compulsive insanity got worse and worse.

My little family and I ended up a year after my son was born back at my parent's house. There I spent my last 6 mths. of using. My hasband left, got arrested and went into a recovery house. At this point, I was completely incapable of caring for my son or myself. My mother took over my son. I was lucky to be able to get out of bed in the morning to try to hustle for the day. I was dying and I knew it - I was praying to God for death.

8 WE DO RECOVER ⑨

A Identification

Prescription addicts are usually the last to find out so we will put them first here. Legal doses of prescribed medication can addict a person because of unknown side effects, combination with other drugs or an inborn ~~potentiality~~ susceptability to become addicted. The individual is usually u unaware that any real problem exists until a prescription lapses or they begin to experience failure in ~~unacceptable~~ Their living. They start losing jobs, become divorced, find themselves without friends and are unable to account for these changes. Generally their use of drugs will increase with these changes. They can in this condition indefinitely or increase their dosages or types of drugs by various means. If at any point they make the basic connection between their use of drugs and the way things have been going for them, they can begin their recovery by seeking help. If they persist in their usage, they become insane by degrees. Denial can overcome the most obvious evidence of addiction and prolong the active addiction. Acceptance is of the fact of addiction is the only way out. Well meaning ~~mmm~~ family members can enable them to continue using by compensating for their inadequacies, getting them out of jams, giving them money and accepting their rationalizations. The addict is usually very effective in encouraging this sort of special treatment. It can in fact become a way of life for them. Recovery depends on reality to provide them with enough pain to where they want to recovery. Prescription addiction is every bit as painful and horrible as the more notorious forms of addiction. ~~Doctors and federal agencies are becoming~~

8-A

At the end we are consumed with terror and dispair. We know for sure that we are dying and many of our friends are usually dead. No one can explain the incredible fact that addicts confirmed beyond hope in their addiction can and do reach for and recieve help in Narcotics Anonymous!

WE DO RECOVER B#1. (10)

8-B-1

In my new life today I don't want to screen myself off ffom reality. If I'm not prefectly happy, I want to change things to suit me or at least be able to face things as they are and accept them. I don't want to live behind smoke. I don't want living problems to creep into my life again. I don't trust drugs anymore. They have killed many people who I have loved. They burnt me out past the funny part where you can turn it off. One toke would set off all the confusion from when I came off a month speed run that set be back for over two years.

These were the first sumptoms we sustained, or were able to admit. Presently, we cleared up our thinking, sometimes with sudden frantic dashes and at other times gradually we saw where our using had been addictive and therefore by definition insane. Insane the way we understand it is poisening one's self for no other apparent reason except that a compulsion or obsession drives the addict to desire his or her drug of choice so badly that there are not many things they would not do to procure that drug and mainline, ingest or inhale it. Insanity for us seems to occur in tragic cycles much like Russian roulet that we are more or less forced to play because we have tried and couldn't stop or wouldn't. The wouldn't is simply the insanity. 0132

#8 B 1

RECOVERY PROCESS

It has become noticeable as our program has grown in our area that many newcomers seem to come in with a false impression that may need to be corrected. In the instances we are talking about, the new man or woman seems to believe that they can barter non-usage for group acceptance and support. This may work for a while but whenever the group fails to behave in accordance with the newcomers expectations they seem to feel that it's ok to use, after all the group has failed to, live up to it's bargain by meeting their needs and they use. The sad thing about this is that it may take them awhile to get the real message of our program: that if they apply the 12 Steps to their problems with their addiction, they can learn to live drug free lives. If they happen to be addicts they can die never realizing that recovery is possible. They seem to overlook the fact that they are the ones who face jails, institutions and death without the program working in their lives.

U pon adapting the new patterns of chemical abstinance one day at a tiie, going to N A meetings and the How of the program we came to see life in a new light, a whirl of confusion that was slowly spinning itself out. We confessed to be of addictive nature and therefore addicts. We found furthermore that an addict using differs from that of the established norm and is set apart by marked obsession (fixed patterns of thought, seemingly inescapable) and compulsion (a physical craving for the potent drug of our choice or any drug) and physicall discomfort when we were away from our drugs for prolonged periods. 0132

(11)

#8 We Do Recover

B. #1 deciding to live

At this time I was getting reallly paranodd. I could not stop drinking and the compulsion was strong and uncontrollablex as herion, coke, methadone, etc. I couldn't go on. I feared total insanity. I feared being locked up again. Lonliness had set in. I was in a bad way. I hated myself, God, and you.and everything I thought of.

0105

The ship was filled with frustration, anger and resentment. I couldn't get to meetings in San Francisco decause we were standing eight on and four off, cleaning the tanks. In order to get to a meeting, I had to pay someone to stand my watch for me. People were relying on me because I was productive, responsible and reliable. I got the work done but I wasn't happy because there was no program on the ship.

0059 At the end we are consumed with terror and dispair. We know for sure that we are dying and many of our friends are usually dead. No one can explain the incredible fact that addicts confirmed beyond hope in their addiction can and do reach for and recieve help in Narcotics Anonymous.

I found a higher power I accept and allow to help me. I believe I had a rebirth- a spiritual awakening-the day I walked in. I have not had an obsession to use or drink since that day and I know that I am not the same person who sat in a bathroom with blood spattered all over trying to find a vein to fix that dime bag in that wouldn't even get me well -------- Hopeless & Helpless.

8-B-1

FANTASY TO REALITY

0105

I was introduced to alcohol, drugs and the world of fantasy found in books when I was about three years old, and for the next thirty years, lived in a world of fairy tales, with the help of alcohol and drugs. I believed that by taking a magic potion, I could turn into whoever or whatever I wanted. There were also times I took potions that I didn't like the results of, but I took them anyway, because they were there.

The favorite "spells" I cast on myself were to become some kind of supernatural, superhuman creature with PCP, to become energetic (and I thought efficient) with amphetamines, and to turn everything off with alcohol. Needless to say, it all backfired and I began looking for another way. Around 1968, I was introduced to Narcotics Anonymous, and also began studying a spiritual philosophy--but I didn't realize that I had to stop using drugs and alcohol in order to create any changes in my life.

8 WE DO RECOVER

B# 1. DECIDING TO LIVE

(12)

One of the first things we learn is that you can't ~~do it for~~ work your program for another person. We have to want it for ourselves, for our own lives to get better.

Through fright, desperation, and God's grace, I had been chemically abstinent for almost a year when I came into AA. My problems had snowballed during that year, and I had developed some severe emotional problems. The truth of the matter was that I didn't know how to live sober, with no props. All I had going for me was that I wanted to learn how.

0156

With love and concern, I want to try to address a difficulty I see a few members of Narcotics Anonymous going through. They are members by right of their desire for recovery but they prolong their suffering in a remarkable manner. Coming into the program, they find relief from their addiction and experience a little recovery. As time goes by they go to a lot of meetings and build personal ties with a lot of members. When it comes to their steps, however, they have in common an incredible dodge. They bounce back and forth not from the program to the streets and back again. They seek their recovery from other programs and the process of recovery is interupted. I don't think they would have any great trouble if they could make complete surrender. They would work the Steps and experience the new freedom. But they don't. About the time they have reached a certain phase of closeness with their new people they again swith over and come back to NA again, for the "love and identity". We welcome them back but as soon as we starting getting close to them, they switch again. It has gotten to be a regular thing for some of these addicts seeking help.

7-B

My part in the story started a long time ago. I joined the fellowship of AA a little over five years ago. It was the only thing I could think of to do, at the time. Through fright, desperation and God's grace, I had been chemically abstinent for almost a year when I came into AA. My problems had snowballed during that year, and I had developed some severe emotional problems. The truth of the matter was that I didn't know how to live sober, with no props. All I had going for me was that I wanted to learn how. When I first stopped drinking and drugging, I was only twenty years old, and although I had some street-wisdom, I was a complete baby when it came to living in the society that I had so violently shunned. My addiction was, at first, to anything I could find that would get me off. I used a lot of uppers, way too much acid, and anything smokable I could find. I tried to use barbiturates, but it took a serious drinking problem, years later, to adjust my body to a point where I could even function with them. I took whatever I could find, as a teen-ager, no matter what it was. The only reason I never got into needles was because the people I knew that were into them either wouldn't share, or they were too high to hit me up. I was too chicken to try it by myself. Although booze was not very cool, as far as I was concerned, and I stayed away from it for most of four years of partying, eventually I got a taste for it, and that taste nearly did me in. I stayed either drunk or in jail for most of my nineteenth year, and there was no doubt in my mind about whether or not I was strung-out. I had to have it, at all costs. I witnessed a lot of death and destruction, so I had a lot of pain to kill.

0165

Three and a half years ago I made a decision to leave my wife; packed up my clothes and asked my parents one more time for help. For the first time since I was sixteen they allowed me back in their house to kick. I was there for two days and my wife brought me a couple of spoons and an outfit. It was a Monday afternoon and I was feeling sick. I told my mom I was going to soak in a bath. As I sat in the tub I took out the dope. Just as I was getting ready to cook it up, in walks mom. She grabbed the spoon and dumped the stuff down the tolet. As sick as I was, I probably would have shot all the water in the toilet if I thought it would get me well but she flushed the toilet and I knew it was gone. I grabbed her by the neck and was ready to drown her. It was at that time that I felt I had what I call a spiritual awakening. It was then that I realized I was totally powerless. I broke out in tears and asked God, if he be there, to help me now.

#8 WE DO RECOVER
B#2

/ 6659 It all begins with that first admission and ~~that firs~~ succeeds ~~white chip~~. From that point forward each addict is reminded that a day clean is a day won and any failure is only a temporary set-back rather than a link in an unbreakable chain. every drug addict is a prisioner in his or her own mind, condemed to slow execution by their own sense of guilt. How moral. The ultimate crime that allows a person to act against their true in er n natureand keep doing things they don't really want to do. Not just criminal things but also just doing nothing all day

The fear of loss of control had set in and we were afraid to try out anything different. We knew in our hearts that our foundation was shaky and we didn't want to think about it. Through attending meetings we eventually hear things which let us know that we are not alone We realize that these horrible feelings are a product of our disease and that real freedom is possible. We learn to communica our thoughts and feelings and in time lose a part of the fear that once had us so completely within it's grasp. We learn that it is not our fault that we are susceptable to addiction.

If you have calmness in your heart , you will find peace in your soul

We hope this newsletter will enlarge on one of our basic beliefs, that the best hope for any addict is the practice of personal freedom in abstinence and the maintainence of a simple spiritual program.

Our common experience shows us that when we first come into NA we fill the empty place inside with meetings. The fellowship of recovering addicts who share with us begins to make us feel unlonly. We aee in the shing faces around us, hope. For the first time in a long time we feel a small kernal of hope inside, where before there was only despair.

In the first stages of our active withdrawal from drugs we used meetings, new friends, sponsors to help us learn to feel good and deal with daily events without returning to drugs. We learn the importance of living only one day at a time. We don't have to make a commitmant to stay clean the rest of our lives. We only have to make this decision for one twenty-four hours. Meetings remain for us all the primary source of our recovery.

The only alternattive is to stop using completely, to abstain from even the smallest quantity of drugs in any form. If he is willing to follow this course, and to take advantage of the help available to him, a whole new life can open up for the addict.

#8 We Do Recover

B #2 Ongoing recover

(14)

MAINTAINING HOUR SPIRITUAL CONDITION #0

Recovery from addiction requires us to learn how to feel good and deal with daily events without turning to drugs. In the beginning we will use meetings to help us to do this a day at a time. While the meetings remain the primary source of our recovery, in time we will have friends, a sponsor and members who will turn to us for help. Having these people in our lives will enlarge our personal experience of recovery, help us work the Steps and help us learn to apply spiritual principles in our living.

Honesty, open mindedness and the willingness to try are three principles which guide us in recovery. As we learn to use them in our daily lives we begin to know a new experience of life. We have less need to make excuses or to cover up who we are or what we are. We do however, protect our anonymimnity as an NA member as explained in the twelvth tradition. New ideas become available to us often for the first time. Applying to our lives, these things that have worked for so many others, we develop our own trust of others, and real hope begins.

Imediate and terrifying medical and legal problems often resolve themselves if ~~the addict submitted to the program~~. only we avoid the next pill, fix, and drink. It is crucial that we maintain the memory of what the last fix did for us. When we can see it was the dope that made us crazy, the revolution is begun. Then come hell or high water we'll keepturning it down and avoid the places where it might be offered.

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0059

At that point I was struck with a moment of clarity and saw the insanity for what it was and wanted no more of it. I took the first three steps for real and also what I call step 1-A-- I knew I could not go on using and drinking and expect my life to get anything but worse.

0/03

#8 We Do Recover

B. 3 Physical

(15)

If I can only stay out of the way and not place too many demands on reality.

N.A. is not religious but spiritual like the spirit in a horse. The spiritual basis within is strong enough to support a person with our illness when the time comes for them to reenter society and the Stpps are the raadmap to the sucessful completion of the journey.

0043

> The flood of old emotions and memories surfaced. It was time to deal with them. Deal with them or use. The only door open to me at this point was the 3rd Step. At this time I turned my will and my life over to the care of God as I understood him. To this day, although I usually have to be up against the wall, I always benefit from this step. The next year and a half, I was nuts. I rarely went to meetings, did not trust anybody, and was relying on geographic cures. As a result I spiritually and emotionally bottomed out. I was forced to trust somebody and asked for help for the first time. Since this is an honest program, the reason I actually started socializing and going to meetings was because of my attraction to some of the men in this program; Men have pulled me through a lot of things. On the other hand, involvement in Narcotics Anonymous service helped me seperate principals from personalities, and resulted in me really grasping the Narcotics Anonymous program. I started working the action steps, the fourth and fifth, and currently working the ninth step. These three steps in particular have given me great insight.

0105

Dear N. A..

We'd just like to tell you where we're at in our sobriety. We've just recently left in-patient treatment at Indian Hill Lodge and are now in t he transition phase of the program. One of the ways we maintain our sobriety is by staying involved with N.A. And we're finding sobriety is great! No longer do we get up each morning looking for our next high or do we have to recuporate from the night before. Now we look forward to sunny and sober days with each day being a learning experience about ourselves and other people around us. This is something new to us because we were so wrapped up in curselves and our addiction. Carrying the message is vital to our recovery beacuase we have to give it away to keep it.

Can't by #5

The progression of recovery goes through stages just as the progress of our disease went through stages. The process of sobriety varies amoung individuals. It is my observation that our progress is directly proportional to our efforts. Truly speaking, everything we do, we do for ourselves. Emotional Sobriety requires efforts beyond just staying sober. The progression of recovery is abstract, but on-going. We are all at different stages of healing at different times.

0043

0043

We know that we will never get emotional sobriety untill we have done our best to straighten out the past. We have spent our time getting what we already have and getting rid of what we never had.

, That way we experience sucess at a basic and acceptable level. It is also recommends that we don't go overboard and swamp ourselves with a bunch of new responsibilities just because we suceeded in handlin g_a a few basics. We need a basis for living that is stronger than a physical or mental basis. N.A. is not religious but spiritual like tha spirit in a horse. The spiritual basis within is strong enough to support a person with our illness when the time comes for them to reenter society and the Stpps are the raadmap to the sucessful completion of the journey. It might be well to recognize the fact that society is not normal but composed of imperfect human beings who have learned to live with one another in a manner that shares strength and overcomes individual weaknesses.

empathy "the wordless language of recognition, belief, and faith."

In our addiction, New Year's Eve was a dream come true - an excuse for us to get high. Now that we're sober, we've learned through the program, there are no excuses. So we've chosen to celebrate a different kind of New Year's. A sober one. The members of the N.A. Steering Committee are sponsoring the 3rd annual New Year's Eve Party at Indian Hill Lodge, Beach Lake, Pa. The time is 7:30 PM 12/31/78. We'll have food, fellowship, and fun for all. Then picture midnite - (instead of being too high and passed out or not high enough and pissed off) an N.A. meeting. Is there a more spiritual way to bring in the new year? Come one, come all. It;s just another way to prove there is a better way of life.

8 B 3 Physical

any addictwith a desire to avoid the next pill, fix, or drink aday or a minute at a timeis ready for the program. As their grip on the old ways of thinking and doing begins to relax the mind begins to accept new ideas that lead to a new life. In this new life they find themselves no longer pressed between those who use drugs and those who do not. Their world constantly expands to include new members and eventually members of society at large. Problems that had no solutions became transparent and unreal in the light of our new under standing. Old ideas grudges and resentments fade as we loosen our sick point of view. A warm feeling of belonging replacesthe old hole in the gut. It's no accident though. Nothing is free. We pay for our recovery with our sharing and

0084
8-B-3

#8 B3 Physical

#8 We Do Recover

B #4 Rental

As for my personality, I had really thought of myself as an outgoing, happy-go-lucky girl, but I was wrong, and after years of depending on drugs and other people to make my decisions, I lost almost all ability to socialize.

Today I am a happy grateful addict and alcholic.who loves living. (I used to hate to hear anyone say this, I felt like throwing-up). I went to NA or AA meetings everyday, sometimes three or four per day, I didm't drink or take anything else to get high on. From day one the twelve steps started becoming as part of my life. At first, I allowed only step one to take hold. Today I have no fear whatsoever of going insane or getting high. I am constantly turning my will over to the care of God. Why not? I sure screwed it up when I took charge myself!

Guilt about the past and woorry about the future keep us messed about today.

In 1975 and early 1976 I was getting more and more tired, and consequently more depressed and irritable. The doctors thought my tiredness was caused by depression, I thought my depression was caused by my tiredness. Eventually, after coughing up blood for six months it was discovered I had tuberculosis, so into hospital I went. Shortly after I went into hospital my wife left me, for good. So I had nothing to do but concentrate on getting well.

Old patterns are what got us into so much trouble using. Old patterns are sick patterns,however anything that "works" to help us make it through a new day clean and sober is considered a new pattern. Complete abstinence is one of the first patterns we use in our clean and sober lives. Vigilance, integrity, honesty, openmindedness and willingness to try are all associated with strange and new patterns to the new comer and to clean and sober drug addicts as a whole.

0132

#8 - We do recovery

B.5 spiritual

(19)

When I started to have doubts about God I had to change my beliefs to a God of my understanding. God as I understand him in love 0054

(0-4)

As long as there has been people, addiction in the form of habitual recourse has existed. Addiction in the form of chemical recourse to drugs to induce synthetic states of oblivion or awareness has become a major health problem as modern ~~medicine~~ technology has made available not only the drugs themselves but also the stresses and personal demands that bring out the potential for addiction and help activate it. In Narcotics Anonymous we are more concerned with recovery than plumbing the mysteries of addiction. We seek to change our personalities for the better and our lives change for the better only after we have begun to change ourselves. Narcotics Anonymous is a safe haven for addicts to seek help. Our program rests strongly in the accumulated experience of those who have gone before so that we may avoid their errors and benefit from their sucesses. The Twelve Steps chart the course of an individuals recovery from the hazy days of powerlessness and unmanageability to the levels of spiritual awakening.

Our conscious awareness is on a higher level and it begins to show. People begin to seek us out. Our minds were consciousness in a contracted form which begins to expand through the program. Cream always rises to the top! 0043

Over a period of years old habit patterns become familiar and many times the comfortalbe mode of our existence. Our egos were all down ~~x~~ blown out of wack. Then we become uncomfortable due to the progression of the obsessive and compulsive nature of our illness, chemical addiction. The old comfort associated with addiction was lost. Life was addiction- a lonely, miserable prison. 0132

We learn mind control and change from external to internal modes of orientation and behavior. We realize that we are responsible for the way we feel. We are no longer controlled by what others do or say. We learn to be responsible members of the society we rejected. We no longer shift the blame and are aware that we create the world in which we live. We are the products of our own thoughts. 0047

#8 WE DO RECOVER B#5 SPIRITUAL (20)

We become aware of pendulum swings in many areas. Extremes of feelings and extremes of reactions become apparent. We learn to recognize and handle these and get back on the path.

0043

As we begin the process of seeking out and stripping ourselves of false ego and pride, we begin to accept the real self. Through group acceptance comes self acceptance. With self acceptance comes confidence. With confidence comes self-worth and feelings of self-respect. The "ego" begins to "suffer". It becomes less sensitive and there is a decreased need to impress others. Ego is the cause of our greatest pain!

The program recommends that we withdraw the addict from enough demands so that they have a better than even chance of meeting the demands that a remain. That way we experience sucess at a basic and acceptable level. It is also recommends that we don't go overboard and swamp ourselves with a bunch of new responsibilitie just because we suceeded in handlin g_a a few basics. We need a basis for living that is stronger than a physical or mental basis.

#8 WE DO RECOVER
8.6 Living by example

~~2nd Step~~ #0853 -2- Came to Believe (21)

After the drugs get out and they are't influencing our minds, we can read books about God and even try some of the stuff we did when we were using. Doing it clean and s sober now might work beaause the chemicals are out. What did'nt fit in our artifically induced state we have found falls into place when we are in our natural state, chemical free.

If our belief is faulty in any respect, it will limit our recovery. Writing down our belief has helped many of us examine our belief. If we have trouble expressing our belief or writing it down, it is helpful to make sure we have worked step one. The ego deflation of step one generally opens our minds because we feel bad and don't want to go on with the kinds of things we have been putting up with. Belief is the key. It takes a firm belief in a loving God before we can possibly turn our life and will over to it with recovery in mind.

I had found a group of addicts trying to live ~~a day~~ at a time without drugs outside of an institution. They listened and shared their hopes, agonies, ~~stop~~ problems with me. I learned what true friendship and usefulness was. I found I could be honest and didn't have to hide the side of me I didn't like. They taught me that I suffered from a cunning baffling and powerful disease called addiction and in order to live I had to stay clean of all mind altering drugs and work a program of recovery outlined in the 12 steps.

Recovery is the daily practice of a spirtual maintenance program; that add's dimension to my life from which i benefit.
Recovery does not take away from instead it $$$$$ aids me in becoming a working part in the world around me.

#8 WE DO RECOVER

B:6 living by example

We have no responsibility for our disease. Our nbility to respond seems to llie in the area of recovery. We can seek help from others afflicted with our disease who are k enjoying lives free from having to use. In time we find that much more is possible in recovery than we could possibly conceive of in the earlier stages of our recoveries. Our teachability depends hinges on our ability to ~~seek help~~ admit our need for help. This humiliating admission is the beginning of the ~~learning~~ basic learning experience that ~~leads that~~ gives us information on our disease and recovery. As we begin to apply what we have learned, our lives begin to change for the better. No one completely understands this process but thank God we don't have to understand it for it to work for us.

But we learn not to question the ways of God. Instead we look into our own actions and feelings. 0043

0105

Since that time I have not found it necessary to take anything mind-altering and every day has been a beautiful adventure. Reality, as it is, is just fine with me. Without drugs and alcohol I have found that I can function like a normal human being, which to me means accepting myself and the world around me, exactly as it is. Without drugs and alcohol, the steps of this program enable me to live life on its own terms. I've been able to put into practice the philosophy of spiritual living I studied years ago and incorporate it into the third and eleventh steps of Narcotics Anonymous.

In recent weeks, I have really gotten hooked into NA. Since coming into the pre-gram, it has been a life line; now it is also something I enjoy. I need the spiritual comfor and fewwowship that I find at all NA gatherings. I love being with people who understand me and whom I can easily understand. I have reached the point where I cannot see my life without NA.

I am comfortable with the twlve steps, as one is with trusted friends. I love them amd believe in the promise and hope that they offer. Following;the steps - living one day at a time, I can maintain an attitude that is conducive to growhh. I am moving forward in the program and I am cnmforted. (written 8-28-80)

Addicts are people who cannot use drugs or ~~alcohol~~ alcohol. Very few persons in jail or mental institutions have had no experience with drugs. Some even speculate that th e Anonymous Programs are divinely inspired to help us survive in the new super technological age where people must adapt to an envioionment that has never existed before in the history of man.

0059

#8 WE DO RECOVER
8.b. living by example

but the real joy is in the fact that I have learned how to relax and enjoy myself, and what's more, now I have friends. We really are a team, and I am positive that we are all in there, cheering each-other on, reaching out, pulling together.

You are my eyes my ears when I do something wrong you help me help myself by showing me what I cannot see.

I've made many major changes in my living situation in sobriety and have seen that even 0105 when I felt anxious or fearful about making the change, a simple faith in a power greater than myself that I choose to call God, removes the anxiety and fear and it always works out into something good.

Finally I realized I had to make a decision. It was either cop out that I wasn't sober or leave the program and the people. At that time I first realized that I truly had some real friends and thank God for those friends who loved me when I couldn't love myself. I can't begin to tell you about all the miracles that have happened to me since coming to the program. For a guy who came in feeling totally different, having never been arrested, not knowing what the inside of a jail looks like and not believing in a Higher Power, I can honestly say that I have made a 180 degree turn. Today the people who loved me have taught me how to love. Today I know what it's like to be a friend. And most of all what it's like to have friends.

Hast of Tit on them

Why is it easy for me to talk on meetings?

I just talk to the loving God in the Group conscience
-Dean - 2nd tradition

#87B7 Powerlessness

(24)

The program of Narcotics Anonymous has taught me that I don't have anything to prove to anyone in my recovery. I don't talk much about the program except to an addict seeking help. The main thing I say is if you think you might be an addict, get to a meeting. I realize that a real addict is going to resist recovery and will usually find some way to convince themselves that have defeated me personaly so that the things I have shared with them loose the validity that would interfere with their using. I put my trust in the group. If a person tells me that they can smoke pot and suffer no ill side effects there are two ways I can look at it without threatening my own recovery. The first is the possibility that they aren't an addict. The other is that the disease syndrome hasn't become apparent to them yet. I always try to be careful because I don't want to say or do anything that might prevent them from seeking help if the dope turns on them. I have several friends on the program who regard pot as their drug of choice and I can relate to the dispair and lonliness that drove them to seek help from the program.

8-B-7

-2-

Before we have given the program a chance to work in our life, we have a great tendancy to do everything for our our partners in a relationship and leave ourselves out or go to the other extrememand let them do for us what we could do for ourselves and fall in resentment and dispair when they fail to meet our elaborate specifications. 0044

Remembering our own past behavior it is easy to love the person within the addict. We know that if we can reach and awaken the force for life within the addict, it can do anything, even give an addict a new life.

Admission of powerlessness over our addiction and that our lives have become unmanageable is the first step in recovery. It is hard for us because for years most we have been rationalizing our addiction and blaming other people, places and things for our difficulties. Through the miracle of this program we learn to look inward for the roots of our difficulties because we have found that through changing ourselves, we automatically change our relationship to the whole. The recovery process begins with this admission of complete defeat. If their is any reservation in this admission it leaves open the door to self-will run riot and can threaten our recovery and our lives by limiting the sincerity of our desire for recovery and a new life. This limitation can make us less willing to try out things which have worked for others in our condition. It can make us unteachable and force us to repeat the errors of our past for an indefinite length of time.

In N.A. we find a way to go and a way to know and in assocciation with others like ourselves we learn to translate, "KNOWING WHAT TO DO" into "DOING WHAT WE KNOW."

#8 B-7 POWERLESSNESS (27)

it is easy to love the person within the addict. We know that if we can reach and awaken the force for life within the addict, it can do anything, even give an addict a new life.

It all begins with that first admission and ~~that first white chip~~ SURRENDER. From that point forward each addict is reminded that a day clean is a day won and any failure is only a temporary set-back rather than a link in an unbreakable chain. every drug addict is a prisioner in his or her own mind, condemed to slow execution by their own sense of guilt. How moral. The ultimate crime that allows a person to act against their true in er n natureand keep doingg things they don't really want to do. Not just criminal things but also just doing nothing all day. I don't imagine a normal person can imagine just how empty a life can become but if you don't feel anything, you don't feel likedoing anything. We weren't focused on the fulfillment of life but on the emptiness and worthlisness of it all. Failure became a way of life and the peculiar inertia that keeps a persgn going the way they are going act on us and sucess becomes painful.

In recent weeks, I have really gotten hooked into NA. Since coming into the pre-gram, it has been a life line; now it is also something I enjoy. I need the spiritual comfor and fewwowship that I find at all NA gatherings. I love being with people who understand me and whom I can easily understand. I have reached the point where I cannot see my life without NA.

I am comfortable with the twlve steps, as one is with trusted friends. I love them and believe in the promise and hope that they offer. Following;the steps - living one day at a time, I can maintain an attitude that is conducive to growth. I am moving forward in the program and I am cnmforted. (written 8-28-80)

#8 B#7 Powerlessness (26)

0105

In this last year of my sobriety, I've had a baby, started a business, went broke, and have started a relationship. Needless to say there were times when my sanity was debatable. Feeling alienated and sensitive, my friends didn't know how to react to me. I learned alot about self-honesty and honesty with other people. It truly does get better and I'm growing from all my experiences. Tara, my baby girl is now four months old and the most beautiful thing that's happened to me. Looking back, I could never have imagined I would have changed so much. I've finally learned how to love, really love my self and others. I've seen this fellowship grow from three meetings a week to No California's first Narcotics Anonymous Newsletter and it feels good to be a part of it all.

I had to have it, at all costs. I witnessed a lot of death and destruction, so I had a lot of pain to kill.

#0059

In working the 2nd part of the first step, slowly a dramatic realization occurred. I've always had a bunch of stuff but I never learned to take care of it. The daily routines that are necessary to maintain and manage a person's life. The ability to anticipate and respond to the demands of keeping a job, being a good mate, paying bills and generally taking care of business on time. Not just machanically but with love and concern.

ACCEPTANCE

- Not getting my way 0059
- Reality not illusion, good place to start growing
- Surrender to the program and the fact that I am addicted.
- End of struggle, beginning of progress
- It is something that we can do to better our lives
- Acceptance resolves the problem of human perfection we can quit apologizing and denying and get to work being the best we can be.

#8 B#7 Powerlessness (27)



A HELPING HAND

My name is J.D. and I'm one of many inmates here at Buford Georgia who have gotten Narcotics Anonymous while in prison. To tell you of my personal experiences while a member of Narcotics Anonymous would be a pleasure because all of my life I've been self-centered and didn't care about sharing anything with anyone. Since being a member of Narcotics Anonymous here at Buford, I've developed an attitude toward lending a helping hand anyway that I can and if this letter will at least give someone in need an idea to at least check out Narcotics Anonymous whether in prison or on the street, then I will have great satisfaction in knowing that the little I did—did help someone.

The program will help someone who wants to be helped, I say that out of personal experience because when I attended my first meeting, I was in search of help with my drug problems. I enjoyed reading *MAIN LINE* and am also thankful for the many people who took time out to show people like me that they really care.

838 Gratitude

(28)

The first thing which I remember hearing that helped me understand gratitude was the idea that gratitude could be practiced and learned. I though mistakenly that it was something that you either felt or did not feel. I had to learn that gratitude could be developed by dwelling on the good things that had already come into my life. First of all I was grateful for the fact that I no longer had to use drugs to handle my feelings or prevent them. I had come to see the connection between my pain and my addiction. It madeevery day special and meaningful when I thought about the fact that by simply not using, the forces of life could begin to work for me and effect my recovery from my addiction. Having others to share the experience with made it really great and I became accustomed to feeling good more often then not. After that I began to check out the old program saying that recommended practicing an attitude of gratitude. I came to see that my ingratitude was simply a choice that I had learned to make in the wrong way. I found an old man who talked about being in San Francisco with 50¢ in his pocket. He was moaning about his diminished state to another person who was in recovery from addiction who recommended that he could indead be worse off. If he didn't have that 50¢ he would be flat broke. This way he could at least make it across town or get a little coffe or make a phone call. He had options. Also he had come across that 50¢ in some way and if he could do it again he would have a dollar. At the time I thought the guy telling me about being grateful for having 50¢ was playing around with me. I couldn't believe that he really had something serious in mind that would help me with my own problems and bills which I had to pay to survive. I see it a little differently today and I'm grateful for that old guys help. He helped set in motion the forces of recovery which lead me to believe that gratitudde is the price I have to pay for good things in my life. If I let myself sink into my old ways and forget the simple lesson of gratitude that which I have will be taken from me.

H 8 B 8 GRATITUDE

(29)

that something wonderful happens. We find that almost everyone we meet has something to offer that we can receive and needs something that we can offer. Opening these doors and entering them can become a new adventure in living. Knocking down the old ideas and entertaining the new can bring us into a new way of life and teach us to be happy, joyous and free.

Enering a relationship, we have learned to say the words, "I have to put my recovery first. If ever our feelings threaten my recoyery I will have to pull back. If you feel like I'm threatening your recovery, you have to tell me and if I feel like you're threatening my recovery I'll have to tell you. Please understand if either of us get loaded it will threaten our lives and we have to put our recovery first.

There are no well defined rules on t is. The important thing to look at is to keep self-will run riot out of our spiritual relationships. Many find a godd and long lasting sponsorship relationship with a member of the opposite sex. Those who succeed in thid usually keep sex and other worldly matters out of the way. In other words the self will and ego defeats the process of mecovery, not the sex of the persons involved althougth it id easier for some to criticize along sexual lines than to look deeper into the truth of the matter. Looking forht e God in the other person helps us learn to put the spiritual values first. We do learn to do this. Most of us have had so much experience along sexual lines that it would be dishonest to represent ourselves as prudes. We are interested in recovery from our active addiction and in learning to live new lives. When we get with others seeking knowledge of God's will for us we can express ideas that don't otherwise come to us and shake off old i eas that have held us back for a long time.

One of the primary reasons we addicts have trouble in the area of relations with others romantic or otherwise is we are so confused that it's hadd for the other person to tell where we'll be coming from day to day. In time we tend to settle down and it's easier for others to befriend us. The better we know and accept ourselves, the beter we can know and accept others as they are. We are notorious for forgetting that we can only change ourselves, not others.

to another. I felt lucky to be clean myself, but I felt more and more isolated, more and more different, as time wore on. It was weird watching the progression. First, they would get clean, then they would go out and try it again, then they would get clean again, and this time they were just going to drink.

We do recover

8. B. 8. gratitude

When I first came to the program, I had a lot to learn. One area that was especially difficult was that of gratitude. I didn't see where I had much to really be grateful for. I can see today that in reality I was taking a lot for granted. By failing to be consciously thankful for that which life and God had already ppovided for me in the way of being able to earn a living, get along with folks and having enough af an understanding to get me through a day, I set myself a trap. In stead of projecting happiness and joy in contact with other people or dwelling on that which had been given me, I would wallow in self-pity and remorse over those things which I had had in the past and had lost through my ingrtitude. I waxed irritable and felt myself unjustly wronged by life itself. I developed and maintained a condition of ingratitude so strong that if a few good things came my way, I was unable to accept them or really say and feel thank you to those who had most likely gone out of their way to help me or show me consideration beyond that which I had really earned. It was difficult if not impossible to really give 100% effort in any area because I had developed the habit of feeling bad and expecting the worse.

We learn that conflicts are a part of reality and learn to be grateful for them. We learn new ways to resolve conflicts instead of running from them. We begin to simplify them are actually look upon them with graditude and as progress and part of the real world. We learn to handle problems, not to solve them. Everyone has situations, we have tended to make them problems.

It will be taken from me not by any outside agency but by my own inability to take care of what I have. Where I come from I wanted everything but I was unable to be grateful for anything that I actually got. As long as I didn't have something, it would deem wonderful and I would often think if I just had so and so I would be happy. Occassionally I would have my prayers answered only to find the rich feelings of satisfaction and comfort beyond my reach. Today I have learned to associate these good feelings with gratitude. I had to practice gratitude the way a one legged man strapp on an artificial leg. It would support me but it had no feeling. In time, clean and sober, the feeling came back.

I don't imagine a normal person can imagine just how empty a life can become but if you don't feel anything, you don't feel likedoing anything. We weren't focused on the fulfillment of life but on the emptiness and worthlisness of it all. Failure became a way of life and the peculiar inertia that keeps a person going the way they are going act on us and sucess becomes painful

#8 B 8 Gratitude

(31)

I am truly a living miracle. Today I am working and have friends and a place to live, I am in a relationship and loved. I can love others and share with others in a joy that is unexpressable. * It might be well to recognize the fact that society is not normal but composed of imperfect human beings who have learned to live with one another in a manner that shares strength and overcomes individual weaknesses.

empathy - "the wordless language of recognition, belief, and faith."

With a new sense of awareness, there is a tendency to make mountains out of mole hills. We are aware of restlessness and conflicts, but we learn to say "How important is it?" There is a tendency to use Transference (Shopping Sprees), but gradually we begin to learn the virtues of patience and persistance and begin to make compromises with reality. There is no Utopia, nothing is perfect, but some things are better than others. Sobriety and reality are better than loneliness and dispair. 0043

I can remember several years ago in my addiction of running into people in halfway houses or those who have been through rehabilitation places and hearing about these things, but I never could imagine or never gave a thought at that time I was going to be one. That was only for bad people or for someone with alot of problems. Today thanks to my Higher Power which I choose to call God, the detox, and the rehab. I went through, and to all the beautiful friends in NA & AA, after two and one half years of being sober one day at a time, I realize I belong.

John Y. 0107

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DECISION MAKING 0107

Making a sober decision is a very growing experience. Really being honest with ourselves, and thinking of both the negative and the positive sides to things...Is this the right decision?...Will it be beneficial to me in my sobriety?...Can I handle it?...Am I being realistic?

Decision making is a little rough at first, especially when you have time to change your mind. Sticking to and suceeding at something and seeing that you had made the right decision is the reward.

Before I had gotten sober, all of my decisions were made on impulse, I never gave any thought to anything, and even if I did I would say the heck with it and carry through with the negative anyway. It is getting better for me withpractice and the help of my sponsor and other NA & AA friends. THANK GOD FOR MY SOBRIETY!

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#8 - B.

9 creative freedom

#0055

realities we must become familiar with. Anyone who ~~have~~ has enjoyed the thrill of seeing a new comer blossom in a few months into a joyous human being will know what I mean. In any case, powerlessness is our delima and most addicts are relieved when they find out they are free to believe or disbelieve as they like. Many addicts are honestly agnostic or athiestic and clean up by using their group as their higher power. Whatever your belief is, we are with you in fellowship and rest assured their is much we have to offer one another.

Today I sit quietly in my room and think of the beautiful miracle of recovery. Yesterday Elliott and I sat on the wall by the Clubhouse of the Rising Sun eating barbecue chicken and listening to the bluegrass music. I used to get a head count of my fellow addicts at each function or meeting at the clubhouse. But in the short six months since that cold February day when I came in, that has become wonderfully impossible. Hell I couldn't even count the cars packed like sardines in our small lot. The miracle of recovery! Speed freaks, pot heads, acid freaks, pill freaks, ex-cons, ex-hookers . . . A year or so ago you wouldn't have wanted to meet any of these people on the street even if you were one of them. Today they are beautiful wonderful people and I can only thank God that He made me a drug addict so that I can have the divine ecstasy of walking among them as one of them. I now think back and remember the haunting refrain of a song I once heard as a child: "The Love of God is greater far than word or pen can tell. It reaches from the farthest star down into the lowest Hell."

0105

God may not have let us into Heaven but He opened the gates of hell and let us out. But wait! He did let us into heaven! Sitting on that fence with Elliott and Bo and talking to Cliff and Rebecca and watching all the beautiful other people—God's people. If heaven is any better than this I don't know if I can stand it.

God, you lifted up my eyes at last. At last you let me walk among your people. You gave me the same disease they have and you took away the dope from me as you did from them. Now you let me join hands in the fellowship of the greatest human beings on the face of this earth! My fellow recovering drug addicts. And that is the miracle of recovery!

#8 We Do Recover

B. 9 Creative Freedom

(33)

I'm a recovering addict who is celebrating a year of sobriety in March. Each day has been a living & learning esperience & alot of days a struggle. I'm learning how to live after 4 years of actively using and existing and being blinded from reality. Today I feel like a little baby, becoming aware of everything that is around me, and not knowing things about life and finding out and learning through asking. So many things about life and finding out and learning through asking. So many things I learned by being sober like how to open a checking account, how to work and put effort in and be honest. I'm learning how to love and how to budget. I'm learning how to rollerskate, I'm still tense, but it's great because people in the program understand because they went through it to. It seems like we all have to learn how to live all over

O/C

0105

In March I made a change that I never imagined I would— I got married. I didn't think I would ever feel secure enough to make that committment again, but my God has a way of showing me that He/She is running the show, not me, and made me an offer I couldn't refuse. Today, not only do I get to live my Program, but I am able to share it with my husband (who I am able to love exactly as he is) and I am extremely grateful for this ability to love, share and accept that would have been impossible to develope without the Steps of Narcotics Anonymous (and its big sister Alcoholics Anonymous). When I came into the Program I had no specific idea of how my life would get better, just that it could and would. And it did, and still is getting better.

Fortunately we can also share a bond of love. We can reach out and grasp one another, each unable to maintain as an individual, but receiving strength and comfort in our shared humality. Together we can release our fears and anger, release the tormenting ideas of a necessary super existence. The need for excitement, of stimulation, of self-aggrandizement can leave us. In our peace and quiet being we can then begin to come into contact with a deeper part of ourselves. ~~The~~ symbiotic

#8 B-10 Promises

(34)

At the end we are consumed with terror and dispair. We know for sure that we are dying and many of our friends are usually dead. No one can explain the incredible fact that addicts confirmed beyond hope in their addiction can and do reach for and recieve help in Narcotics Anonymous. Where else for an hou r and the price of a cup of coffeecan you get a new life? Their exists no model of the recovered addict. When the drugs go and the addicts works the program, strange and wonderful things happen. New possibilities spring up like flowers in the desert. Lost dreams awaken. The juices of life begin to flow. Imediate and terrifying medical and legal problems often resolve themselves if ~~the addict works the program~~, only we avoid the next pill, fix, and drink. It is crucial that we maintain the memory of what the last fix did for us. When we can see it was the dope that made us crazy, the revolution is begun. Then come hell or high water we'll keepturning it down and avoid the places where it might be offered. Addicts are people who cannot use drugs or ~~drink~~ alcohol. Very few persons in jail or mental institutions have had no experience with drugs. Some even speculate that th e Anonymous Programs are divinely inspired to help us survive in the new super technological age where people must adapt to an envioionment that has never existed before in the history of man. Future shock!

8 B-11

we belive in the Power of a Loving God to handle all that we cannot. 0156 We hope that by dragging this phenonmenon out of the shadows some members can find ways to address this anda other areas of concern so that we can better carry our message to the addict who still suffers. I for one of many find NA well equiped to provide the ongoing recovery I need for a new life which I learn to enjoy a day at a time. Their are no needs or opportunities for growth that the Program does not provide me with.

As we work the steps we will gain new freedoms in many areas. Awareness of character defects will determine areas of growth. These areas differ from individual to individual. Do not compare your progress with anyone else. Compare your progress with what you used to be and with your Spiritual Progress.

#8 B10 Promises

We become aware that many of our feelings about sex and society were immature and based upon pride and ego. We become more comfortable with our sexuality.

We appreciate more fully the meaning of living one day at a time. We get over the guilt of the past and worry of the future. We enjoy the now. We learn to survive both pain and pleasure. We endure frustation for we know that "this too shall pass."

We rid ourselves od absolutes such as absolute success or absolute failure and begin to enjoy doing for the fun of it rather than shying away because we are not perfect.

Interpersonal relationships improve. Our feelings are less easily hurt and we become less sensitive and suspicious. Our dependency upon acceptance and approval from others deminishes.

We begin to understand the meaning of the principle of Love. We recognize that we are growing from an immature need for love to a more mature giving of love. We begin to care about others.

0043

Our inappropriate emotional explosions decrease.

We are no longer lonely or feel different. We realize that we are a part of the universe.

As we change in recovery, we are not really changing our basic nature, we need to change our reactions, thoughts, and attitudes. We begin to understand who we are. "Know Thyself" begins to make sense and we understand our basic identity. This gives us a sense of security without forgetting what we are.

We become less compulsive in our thoughts and actions.

Spiritual Progress is necessary and we must want this and be willing to make the necessary effort. This is a very personal and individual area and our Higher Power reveals Itself in many ways if we recognize it. Spiritual progress and Spiritual awareness becomes an apparent and integral part of all our affairs. If we take one step toward God, He will take seven steps toward us. An attitude of indifference or intolernace toward Spiritual Principles will defeat us! It is the fashion these days to institute an inquiry into everything that happens.

Perhaps this chapter can best serve by providing a basis for identification with the program for the person who thinks drug addiction might be at the root of their problems. Addicts come from all backgrounds. The drugs addicts use may be legal or illegal. The dosages may be light or heavy. The effects of the drug of choice may be mild or devastating. The Characteristics of associated with addiction may be noticed or unnoticed. We hope our general experience will help a person decide for themselves, if their problem may be our problem or if our help may be their help.

For us an addict is a person who uses drugs in any form to the extent that they cannot live normally with or without them. They have passed a point of return and must have outside help if they are to regain any sort of normal life.

#8 B10 Promises

(36)

A meeting of Narcotics Anonymous is a tremendous reservoir of cleanliness and sobriety.

It is in a meeting that the seeds of sobriety are sown, take root, sprout, bloom and harvest. The meeting waters our garden and keeps it fresh. 0036

How many times have we heard something said over and over in a meeting until it finally takes seed and blossoms? With each meeting we attend seeds planted in earlier meetings are watered until even we can see them growing.

What grows in the garden is harvested by our sharing experience, strength and hope in a meeting. And while this harvesting is taking place in one of the fields of our garden, other fields in the individual and the group are being sown to be harvested at more meetings. This harvest is a form of spiritual progress.

By using the negative events that happen as fertilizer, our positive crop grows through it to the spiritual abundance of the N.A. fellowship. Looking for the gratitude and lesson in an experience helps to cultivate the garden.

The 12-Steps of N.A. are the very tools we need to weed the garden and keep it growing along spiritual lines. And while the garden is this well-being of the spirit, the Master Gardener cares for all the rest the garden needs.

Through listening to the experience of others and learning how to apply this to me, life has become pleasant, beautiful and sometimes very exciting. Laughter is a common part of my day. Smiling doesn't hurt at all and I am able to look anyone in the eye. At times when the going gets rough, I can turn to my sponsor, group, God or literature (ther ins't an NA book - yet) not necessarily in that order either. On different days it works different ways.

Recently I was fortunate enough to experience the 9th annual NA World Convention. Words cannot describe the unity felt there in Atlanta. I brought back so much more than I took, just as it is in the NA m meetings.

I really don't have any ~~answers~~ brilliant answers or solutions but I can honestly say this program works. I've never cleaned-up or sobered-up without being locked up until now. Each day, one at a time, is another record of sucess for this addict. So long as I listen to what I'm told it keeps getting better and better! What they tell me is,"Keep coming back, it works!"

#8 B10 Promises

(37)

~~for which there is no~~ cure. We can stay clean and sober, and even have fun! If we remember to do this one day at a time. Just don't take a fix, pill or drink today and sooner or later everything will be fine. 8-B-10

Rewards of sobriety...I used to think life would be so boring, a real drag being sober. No hope without dope. I was really screwed up in my addiction and my concept of Sobriety was just as screwed up. Now that everything is changing and forever getting better, I give thanks for the NA & AA programs. 0107

My way was so self-destructive, hurting many along the way. Learning a new way of life is a blessing from God I don't deserve, but I'm surely grateful thanking him daily for all the new friends and asking for knowledge of his will and the power to carry it out. Keep it simple, I have a long way to go, one day at a time, so easy does it, but do it. Paul B.

Where else for an hour and the price of a cup of coffeecan you get a new life? Their exists no model of the recovered addict. When the drugs go and the addicts works the program, strange and wonderful things happen. New possibilities spring up like flowers in the desert. 0109 Lost dreams awaken. The juices of life begin to flow. Imediate and terrifying medical and legal problems often resolve themselves if ~~the addict who submitted to the program~~. only we avoid the next pill, fix, and drink.

In personal growth we use both freedom and goodwill in cooperation with others. We realize we cannot live alone, that personal is also inter-personal. To find better balance, we examine spiritual, personal and social values as well as material values; maturity seems to demand this kind of evaluation. In active addiction, insanity, institutions and death are the only ends. With recovery through the help of a higher Power and the Steps of N.A., anything is possible. 0086

We will be at different levels at different times. At one time in our lives we had a set of ideals and morals and some idea of the role we wanted to play in life. Often these objectives have been lost. As recovery progresses we realize that we are beginning to be the person that we wanted to be. 0100

That no matter what we have done or what course our addiction has taken that we can relax 0059 and soak up the love that comes otu and fills the room in the course of every meeting.

. We are limited our growth only by our ability to conceive how far we can go. 0043

#8 -- We do recover (38)

B. 10. promises - the lie is dead

 #0064

no model of the recovered addict. When the drugs go and an addict becomes a part of the program, strange and wonderful things happen. New possibilities spring up like flowers in the desert. Lost dreams awaken. The juices of life begin to flow again. The body cleans itself. Immediate and terrifying medical and legal problems often resolve themselves if only we avoid the next pill, fix or drink. (1). We want to remember what the last pill fix or drink did for us. (2) When we can see it was the dope that made us crazy, the revolution is begun. Then we'll keep turning it down and avoid the places x where it might be offered. Addicts are people who cannot use drugs. Experience has taught us that alcohol is a drug.

If you are an addict and have found this book, please give yourself a break and read it. Noone is perfect and this book is the work of imperfect humans but it id your book. We wrote it for you, thinking of how we used to be and our many dead friends and our many living friends in the program of Narcotics Anonymous.

#6 0086

With freedom, life is a meaningful, changing, and exhilarating process. It looks forward with a reasonable expectancy to a better and richer realization of our desires and a greater fulfillment of our personal selves. These are of course some of the manifestations of the spiritual progress that results from the daily practice of the 12 Steps of N.A.

0105

My life now is fuller than it ever has been. I have been working at the same job for over a year now, and I get along pretty well with my parents. That is admirable, but the real joy is in the fact that I have learned how to relax and enjoy myself, and what's more, now I have friends. We really are a team, and I am positive that we are all in there, cheering each other on, reaching out, pulling together.